She came to inventory an archive.
The archive was expecting her.

Miranda Cale is hired to catalogue a missing scientist's estate. Eleven doors on the county plan. Twelve in her inventory. Inside are sealed experiments, meticulous transcripts, and an artificial intelligence built to speak in the voices of the dead. Then three isolated conversations produce the same interruption, and a document written before her arrival begins to describe her work.

Following the evidence from a historian's experiment to a program that has abolished the right to leave, Miranda begins to suspect that her commission is part of the experiment. The archive is assembling something. It may already be using her.

If a voice is reconstructed from a person's words, what survives: the person, a fiction, or something for which we have no name? Can a simulation have a right to refuse? And when AI-generated fiction enters the record as evidence, who decides what is real?

Built from a real public archive and told through inventories, correspondence, transcripts, and competing hands in the margins, Using This Matter draws the reader into the unstable space between a convincing imitation and a presence that can no longer be dismissed.

A NOVEL

USING THIS MATTER

JACOB E. THOMAS, MA, PhD

USING THIS MATTER

A Novel of the Companion Estate



JACOB E. THOMAS, MA, PhD